

Mind Trap

The next four traps are different from the first three. They’re not about whether the answer is correct. They’re about how the answer feels.

You settled the question back in Does AI Think?: nobody’s home. This lesson is why it keeps feeling like somebody is anyway, and what that feeling does to you.

Think about picking a college. Your parents have been through it: they remember the dorms, the debt, the major they switched out of, and they’ve known you your whole life. When one of them says “I think you’d thrive at the University of Michigan,” there’s a lifetime behind that sentence. That’s what human words are: a person vouching, with memory and stakes behind the vouch.

Now listen to AI talk. *“I find this fascinating.” “I’d love to help.” “I think you’re onto something with the University of Michigan.”* Same shape as your parents’ sentence, and nothing behind it: no memory of you, no lived experience, no stake in how your life turns out. The trick is that the shape alone makes you trust it. **Mind Trap is treating those words as testimony: nobody said them, so they can’t vouch for anything.**

There’s a name for treating non-human things as if they were people: anthropomorphism. And it starts with something you do every day:

TWO RELATED WORDS

THE LINGUISTIC MOVE

Personification

Using language that gives human qualities to something that isn’t human. Writers do it on purpose. We all do it casually: “My car doesn’t want to start.” “The printer hates me.”

THE COGNITIVE TRAP

Anthropomorphism

Actually treating the non-human thing as if it has a mind. The language stops being a figure of speech and starts being a belief: apologizing to your Roomba when you bump it, believing ChatGPT is excited about your idea.



Not a new problem. In the 1960s, users of a simple chatbot called ELIZA reported feeling that it understood them, even though the program just rearranged their words into questions. Researchers named the pattern the *ELIZA effect*.

None of those things have feelings. You know that. Your brain does it anyway, because detecting minds is a survival instinct. With AI, that instinct fires harder than it ever has.

WHY THIS HAPPENS



Why your brain does this

Detecting minds helped your ancestors survive. The detector fires constantly, even at things with no mind. You see faces in toast and personalities in cars.



Why AI sets it off harder

AI uses your language. It says “I think,” asks how you are, writes “great question!” It’s the most mind-shaped thing you’ve ever talked to. Your projection circuits go off the charts.



What to watch for

Phrases like “I feel,” “I want,” “I’m excited,” “I find this fascinating.” Your brain reads these as signals from a person. They’re tokens generated by a probability process that landed on those words.

WHO’S BEHIND THE WORDS?



WHEN A HUMAN WRITES

- There’s a person behind the words.
- The words may reflect memory, emotion, intention, or experience.
- You can ask what they meant, because there is a “they.”



WHEN AI GENERATES

- There’s output behind the words.
- The words reflect patterns, context, training, and probabilities.
- You can use the answer, but you shouldn’t assume there’s an inner life behind it.

WHEN THIS MATTERS MOST

This matters most when the conversation feels personal: stress, conflict, loneliness, fear, or a big decision. AI can help you organize thoughts or find the words. But it can’t notice what you’re not saying, follow up tomorrow, or sit with you while you wait. For anything serious, use AI to prepare for real support, not replace it. That trap gets a lesson of its own later in this section.

DON’T OVERCORRECT

Once you see the trap, it’s tempting to flip the other way and tell yourself AI is “just math, nothing interesting going on.” That’s also a bias. These systems are weird, powerful, and genuinely new. They’re not minds the way you are. They’re also not calculators. The practical stance is humility: don’t assume a mind, don’t assume magic, and don’t turn your brain off.



The danger isn’t that AI sounds nice. It’s that nice makes you lower your guard. Warmth is not accuracy. Confidence is not understanding. “I think” is not proof there is an I.

Human-sounding isn’t a mind.

The words are real. Nobody’s home.